Chakung, a town in west Sikkim from where her husband's ancestors came. The kazi belonged to a group of people who were frustrated with Sikkim's 'byzantine electoral system', and with the kazini by his side—and more often behind the scenes—began to advocate for a more democratic order.[36]

In 1953, Thondup's father Tashi had introduced a mild form of constitutional monarchy with a State Council and an Executive Council. But the system was based on a Party Formula, whereby the seats in the State Council would be divided equally among the Bhutia-Lepcha and Nepalese communities, which meant that the constitution made the approximately 75 per cent Nepalese majority of the population equal to the 25 per cent Bhutia-Lepchas. This complicated voting system was replaced with an even more intricate method in 1958 and, in 1967, the strength of the State Council was raised from the initial 18 to 24, with the six additional seats to be nominated by the chogyal.[37]

There was widespread opposition to this undemocratic system, a movement that India encouraged because it would undermine the power of the chogyal, his American wife, and the nationalistic noblemen who supported them. India's involvement increased after a controversial election in January 1973, in which the pro-palace National Party won nine of the 18 contested seats. The two opposition parties, one of which was the kazi's Congress Party, claimed that vote rigging had taken place and demanded that the officials who were responsible for it be arrested. The demands were not met, and anti-chogyal demonstrations, some of them violent, were launched in Gangtok. A temporary solution was found in May, when the chogyal, India's Foreign Secretary Kewal Singh, and representatives of the political parties agreed to introduce a more democratic system. Under the agreement, the chief executive, or the head of the administration, was to be an Indian.[38]

Palace power was falling apart rapidly—and so was Thondup's marriage to Hope. There was infidelity on both sides and, on 15 August, she left with her son and daughter for New York. India's Independence Day was being celebrated in Gangtok. The writing was on the wall, and, in the 1974 election, the first that was really democratic, kazi's Congress Party routed the National Party by capturing 29 of the 32 seats in the new Assembly. One of the first resolutions it passed when it met in May was to reduce the powers of the chogyal. In June, some members of his Sikkim Guard tried,